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*International Review of Victimology* 1990 1: 267

DOI: 10.1177/0269758090000100304

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## CLASSIFYING VICTIMS: A PROPOSED MULTIDIMENSIONAL VICTIMOLOGICAL TYPOLOGY

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### ABSTRACT

Although recent years have witnessed a growing number of studies in victimology, relatively little attention has been paid to the development of classification systems in this field. This paper reviews the existing typologies and points at their primary limitation, namely, their unidimensionality. Hence, the field presently lacks a systematic conceptual framework. After suggesting a revised definition of victim, a multidimensional victimological typology is proposed comprising the following eleven dimensions: the source of victimization; legal framework; intentionality of the perpetrator; identification of the victim; victim vulnerability; the victim's perception of victimization; others' perception of victimization; type of victimization; the severity of victimization/harm; the victim-offender relationship; and the victim's contribution to the event. The various categories within these dimensions are discussed and suggestions are put forward for further developing and refining this conceptual framework.

### INTRODUCTION

Recent years have witnessed a growing number of studies in the field of victimology. The great majority of these studies deal with empirical aspects of victimization in general (e.g. victimization surveys) and/or concentrate on studying specific types of victimization (such as spousal abuse, child abuse, homicide, burglary, etc.), or both. Relatively little attention has been paid to theoretical aspects of victimology, including the field of typology (Flynn, 1982). This is somewhat surprising, since one would expect that being a relatively new area of study, problems of definition and of boundary setting would be an important prerequisite to further studies in victimology.

The development of a multidimensional typology of victimology, once accepted, would serve a variety of uses within the field. For example, the type of events that result in a victimization would be more precisely defined, the severity of victimization be more accurately assessed, and the issues surrounding the victim and potential impact on the victim be more readily determined.

After reviewing and discussing the few existing typologies we shall present an attempt to create an integrated multidimensional typology, which we hope will be of both theoretical and practical value.

## REVIEW OF PREVIOUS TYPOLOGIES

The first victim typology was proposed by Hentig (1948; p. 438) in his pioneering classical work *The Criminal and His Victim*. This typology focuses on victim vulnerability and consists of thirteen categories which can be roughly divided into two main dimensions:

### A. Biological, Demographic and Social Categories.

1. The young
2. The female
3. The old
4. The mentally defective and other mentally deranged
5. Immigrants
6. Minorities
7. Dull normals

Victims in the above categories are vulnerable either due to their age, sex, mental disability or low social status.

### B. Psychological Categories.

8. The depressed
9. The acquisitive
10. The wanton
11. The lonesome and heartbroken
12. The tormented
13. Blocked, exempted and fighting victims

In this group the vulnerability of the victim is primarily created by his/her internal mental state.

Mendelsohn, another pioneer in the field of victimology, proposed a victim typology based mainly on the amount of guilt experienced by the victim in regard to his/her victimization. This typology was summarized by Schafer (1974; p. 19) as follows:

1. The completely innocent victim (e.g. children and those who suffer a crime while they are unconscious).
2. The victim with minor guilt, and victimization resulting from the victim's ignorance (e.g. a woman who 'provokes' a miscarriage and as a result pays with her life).
3. The victim as guilty as the offender, and the voluntary victim (e.g. suicide committed by a couple: desperate lovers or healthy husband and sick wife).
4. The victim who is more guilty than the offender (e.g. the 'provoker victim' or the 'imprudent victim').
5. The most guilty victim, and the victim who is guilty alone (e.g. the attacker who is killed by another in self-defense).
6. The simulating victim, and the imaginary victim (e.g. paranoids, hysterical or senile persons and children).

A similar classification, based on the degree of the victim's participation in the offense is proposed by Fattah (1967). This typology consists of

five major types of victims and eleven subgroups. The five major types are:

1. Non-participating victims: victims who do not contribute to the offense.
2. Latent or predisposed victims: people who because of certain predispositions are more likely than others to be victims of certain types of offenses.
3. Provocative victims: victims who play a definite role in the etiology of the crime, either by inciting the criminal to commit it or by creating a situation likely to lead to crime.
4. Participating victims: victims who play their part while a crime is being committed, either by adopting a passive attitude or making the crime possible, easier, or assisting the criminal.
5. False victims: persons who are not victims at all or are victims of their own actions.

In their well known work, *The Measurement of Delinquency*, Sellin and Wolfgang (1964; pp. 155–156) suggest a typology consisting of five categories based mainly on the victim-offender relationship:

1. Primary victimization: personalized or individual victims.
2. Secondary victimization: commercial establishments such as department stores, railroads and chain stores, the victim being impersonal, commercial, and collective.
3. Tertiary victimization: a very diffuse victimization that extends to the larger community and includes offenses against the public order, social harmony or the administration of government. Regulatory offenses and violations of city ordinances are typical.
4. Mutual victimization: cases in which the participants engage in mutually consenting acts such as fornication, adultery, or statutory rape.
5. No victimization: offenses that could not be committed by an adult and are commonly referred to as 'juvenile status' offenses (e.g. running away from home and truancy from school).

Sellin and Wolfgang's five categories were further elaborated by Silverman (1974) who divided some of them into subcategories in order to facilitate empirical research on the various types of victimization. For example, he subdivided primary victimization into face-to-face and non-face-to-face victimization. In addition, Silverman also suggested that one take into account both the victim's and the offender's perception of the victimization.

Wolfgang and Singer (1978) suggest a number of categories for victim analysis as a possible framework for the advancement of victimological theory and research. Some of these categories relate to dimensions of some of the typologies mentioned above (e.g. victim targets; victim-offender relationships; and victim proneness, contribution and provocation), while others go beyond the scope of the previously mentioned

typologies, such as victim compensation and victim disposition (i.e. the official treatment of victims from the time their victimization is known to the authorities).

The above typologies all have one characteristic in common: they (implicitly or explicitly) pertain to the realm of criminal law. However, the traditional conception of victimology as part of criminology is not shared by all victimologists. A number of scholars strongly suggest a clear departure of victimology from the limiting 'embrace' of the mother-discipline (viz. criminology), and this approach is clearly reflected in the victim typologies they propose. These typologies place a strong emphasis on the sources of victimization. For example, Quinney (1974) suggests that the image of victimization be expanded to include victims of war, victims of the 'correctional system', victims of state violence, and victims of oppression of any sort. Mendelsohn (1974), whose typology based on the degree of the victim's guilt was mentioned earlier, specifies six types of environment that may result in a person becoming a victim:

1. The bio-physical endogenous environment of the victim himself.
2. The natural surrounding milieu which consists of free or controlled forces, or such that have already escaped man's supervision.
3. The milieu of changed natural surroundings. This milieu is the outcome of pollution of the necessary components of life in the natural environment.
4. The social milieu.
5. The antisocial milieu. The policy of a state or a party which claims, by force, the power of a dictatorial, totalitarian or racist government.
6. The driving/mechanical milieu. This milieu is concerned with dangerous industrial or domestic machines as well as with vehicles on the road.

The above classification was further elaborated and refined by Young-Rifai (1982) who suggests five categories of victims that might appear as a result of the contribution of determinants from any or all of the following five environments:

1. The biophysical victim: victims who suffer injustices because of their physical characteristics (e.g. race, hormones and handicaps).
2. Victims suffering injustices due to the impact of their natural surroundings (e.g. earthquakes, floods and drought).
3. Victims who suffer the injustices caused by the interface environment, i.e. the impact of man on the surrounding environment (e.g. pollution of air, water and soil).
4. Victimization by the social milieu. This category is further subdivided into political, economic and cultural victimization. Victimization by 'conventional' crime is included here.
5. Victims of the technological environment (e.g. victims of car accidents, industrial accidents and computer billing errors).

Another approach which expands beyond the scope of criminal law was recently suggested by Knudten (1988a). He defines victimology as a scientific discipline which should focus on the following five major areas:

1. Criminal/penal victimology: included here are victims of traditional crimes against the person and against property, of sex offenses, drug abuse, white collar crime and organized crime.
2. Political victimology: the main categories here involve abuses of power or advantage, abuses of human rights and victimization occasioned by terrorism, military intervention or war. For each of these categories Knudten elaborates sub-categories which specify the varieties of political victimization.
3. Economic victimology: this includes victimization occasioned by accidents, disasters or technological abuses (e.g. traffic, home or work accidents, earthquakes, famines, epidemics, chemical hazards and nuclear disasters), economic abuse (e.g. labor discrimination and abuse, poverty, corporate abuse, bribery and payoffs), and abuses caused by social change and development (e.g. victimization due to environmental abuse, pollution and human displacement).
4. Familial victimology: this deals with victimization in the family – child and spouse abuse and abuse of the elderly – as well as victimization due to divorce or desertion.
5. Medical victimology: this deals with victimisation caused by legal drug abuse (alcohol, drugs, tobacco), abuse of psychiatric procedures (chemical and electro-convulsive therapy, psychosurgery), surgical abuse, and unlawful human experimentation.

These five victimological areas were later presented by Knudten (1988b) as an introduction to a 'dynamic theory of victimization' which is outlined in a series of forty-four propositions.

The typologies reviewed represent attempts to advance systematic thinking in the developing area of victimology. However, the main limitation of each of these typologies is that they are unidimensional. Hentig (1948) focuses only on the sources of victim vulnerability, and his categories are neither exhaustive nor mutually exclusive (Silverman, 1974). Mendelsohn, in his first typology (see Schafer, 1974), deals only with the amount of victim's guilt or responsibility, while Fattah (1967) focuses exclusively on the degree of the victim's participation. Both of these typologies apply only to personal (individual) victims. The victim-offender relationship is the main focus of the typologies offered by Sellin and Wolfgang (1964), Silverman (1974), and Wolfgang and Singer (1978). Mendelsohn (1974), in his second typology, and Young-Rifai (1982) deal exclusively with 'environmental' sources of victimization. Quinney (1974) takes a similar approach, although he does not claim to have formulated a systematic victim typology. Knudten's (1988a) typology or conceptualization of victimology is definitely of interest but his approach is not much more than redefining (and expanding) victimology, and redividing it into

five 'new' areas. Moreover, it is not clear what criterion guides this division. For example, most categories of medical victimology can be defined as white collar crime and thus be included in the area of criminal/penal victimology. Similarly, most categories of familial victimology are also within the realm of criminal law and the author does not specify the reason for defining a special area of familial victimology. Another example is that within the area of economic victimology one finds subcategories such as epidemics (including AIDS), pollution and nuclear disasters. It is quite obvious that while these factors cause also economic damage (and victimization), the economic aspect is definitely not the major one. These and other shortcomings of Knudten's (1988a) classification are due to its basic problem, the lack of a clear guiding principle for the construction of this typology.

The unidimensionality and other limitations of the previous typologies are, in our opinion, a major obstacle to the advancement of victimological theory and research. We strongly believe that in order to advance the field, a comprehensive classification system is called for. In the following we present an outline of our conceptual framework for victimology.

## **A PROPOSED CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK FOR VICTIMOLOGY**

Before describing our multidimensional classification system in detail, we present a definition of victim: a victim is any individual, group, or institution harmed or damaged by others or events who/which may or may not perceive herself/himself/itself/themselves as such, or is or ought to be recognized by others as a victim. A victim may share the experience with others and may seek help, assistance, and redress. Such help may come from public, private, or community agencies.

We recognize that this working definition is not conclusive nor etched in stone and will, over time, need modification. However, a definition of 'victim' is a prerequisite for developing a typology of victimology, and the above definition serves our view of who or what is a victim. It is also recognized that a single definition of victim may be inadequate in addressing the scope of victimization and that more than one definition of victim may be necessary.

Given the limitations of previous typologies, we propose here a multidimensional typology. This typology incorporates all the dimensions covered by previous classifications, and also adds new ones. Moreover, as will be seen, our typology is not a rigid and closed classification system, but rather an open or modular construction of elements that can be changed and improved in the future. This typology consists of the following eleven dimensions: the source of victimization; legal framework; intentionality of the perpetrator; identification of the victim; victim vulnerability; the

victim's perception of victimization; others' perception of victimization; type of victimization; the severity of victimization/harm; the victim-offender relationship; and the victim's contribution to the event.

### **A. The source of victimization**

This dimension contains eight categories.

1. Individual (personal crime): individuals as the primary source of victimization, most commonly individuals who commit a crime against another individual or a group of individuals.
2. Group (organized crime, terrorists, political crime): an example would be the terrorist attack on the Israeli sportsmen at the Munich Olympic Games in 1972.
3. Community: communities have been a long standing source of victimization. Communities may act against an individual or a subgroup in that population. Minority groups, races and religious sects are examples of groups which contain individuals who may fall prey to community victimization.
4. State (political crimes by the state, infringement of civil rights, etc.): an example of such victimization might be a state that makes laws that discriminate against a particular race, sex or other social grouping.
5. Corporate (e.g. safety regulations, consumer fraud and commercial cartels): the Ford Pinto automobile case is a good example.
6. Technological environment (e.g. automobile and industrial accidents). Noteworthy examples of such victimization would be the nuclear accident at Chernobyl, the explosion of the space shuttle Challenger, and the more recent increase in plane crashes in the airline industry.
7. Interface environment (pollution): an example is acid rain.
8. Natural environment (earthquakes, floods, etc.): natural causes are a unique source because they do not generally involve the actions of mankind or intent on the part of any individual. Natural disasters include earthquakes, volcanos, floods, fires, major storms and severe weather systems.

### **B. Legal framework**

This dimension contains four categories.

1. Criminal law. Most nations have a legal code containing rules and laws by which its citizens must abide. Violation of these rules or laws results in the individual or group being charged with a criminal violation.
2. Civil law. In many nations there are no specific criminal laws to protect individuals from certain types of victimization. For example, damage to

reputation is not generally seen as a criminal action. In such cases the damage to an individual falls under civil law in terms of redress. Civil law provides an avenue for victims of such actions to pursue compensation for such damages.

3. Transnational/International Law. Transnational or international law goes beyond the boundary of an individual nation. In an effort to fight terrorism, for example, the development of transnational laws becomes an avenue by which nations can seek a united front against certain forms of victimization. Laws regarding genocide are another example of this legal framework.
4. No legal framework (moral norms, natural sources). This includes actions or events which result in victimization but do not pertain to any legal framework. Moral norms, for example, have no legal framework per se. However, actions against individuals who violate such norms can result in victimization and may result in the violation of a law (e.g. the killing in some Mediterranean societies of a female who has 'brought shame on the name of the family'). Victimization resulting from natural sources is the most obvious example of victimization outside the context of a legal framework, unless the government and/or other authorities are guilty of negligence towards specific citizens or the public in general.

### **C. Intentionality of the perpetrator**

Victimization occurs in many cases as the result of direct action on the part of the perpetrator(s)/victimizer(s). Crimes against property or person, terrorist acts and discrimination against groups of individuals are all examples of deliberate and intentional behavior on the part of the perpetrator(s). In most cases, these victimizations are premeditated and are accompanied by a clear understanding on the part of the perpetrators that they are violating a law and may cause harm or loss to their victim(s). On the other hand, many acts that cause harm or damage are non-intentional and can be defined as reckless, negligent or accidental acts. Thus, the intentionality of the perpetrator falls within one of the following five categories:

1. Intentional. Here the perpetrators have a clear understanding that they are violating a law or rule and may bring about harm or loss to their victim(s). In some cases there may be a direct plan to harm the victim(s) in some way, as in robbery and assault.
2. Recklessness. An example of recklessness (where there is foresight of the possibility of damage or harm) is the recent investigation into airline safety in the United States. Several airlines have deliberately neglected to perform routine safety checks and repairs on aircraft, putting the traveller at increased risk of experiencing an airline accident.

3. **Negligence.** This is defined as those instances in which the perpetrators did not foresee what any reasonable person would have foreseen. For example, a worker is cleaning windows on a scaffolding two stories above the ground. On the scaffolding is a pail filled with cleaning solution. Setting the pail on the edge of the scaffolding behind him, he steps back and knocks the pail to the ground, injuring a passer-by. His actions are negligent, since a reasonable person could have foreseen this injury occurring if the cleaner did not take care.
4. **Accident.** If the above mentioned worker takes the time to place the pail in the middle of the scaffolding in a special holder to prevent any accident, he is taking care; thus should a very strong and unusual gust of wind cause the scaffolding to sway and the pail to tip over and fall to the ground, 'accident' would be appropriate judgment.
5. **Not applicable.** Finally, there are those victimizations that occur that have nothing to do with intent or negligence on the part of another. The most obvious cases here are the natural sources of victimization as described above.

#### **D. Identification of the victim**

This dimension contains five categories.

1. **Individuals.** Every instance of victimization results in harm or damage to an individual. The individual is the basis or foundation of victimology. In many cases, the individual is only one of many affected by a particular source of victimization.
2. **Social Groups.** Victimization often occurs to a group of individuals. Sometimes there is no unifying characteristic of the particular group other than their joint victimization. For example, a group of unrelated individuals may be harmed as a result of a fire in a building caused by an arsonist. In other cases, there may be such a characteristic, such as an act of violence against a specific religious racial or national group. Women, blacks and homosexuals are other examples of specific social groups who may experience victimization.
3. **Corporations and Businesses.** Even financial institutions can be victimized, as was evident in the stock market crash in the U.S.A. on October 19, 1987. When the market fell, international markets were also affected. Several brokerage firms were forced out of business as a result.
4. **Nation(s).** One of the most glaring examples of nations falling victim to a specific source of victimization is the nuclear accident at Chernobyl, as a result of which the Soviet Union and neighboring countries were subject to radio-active fall-out.
5. **Mankind in general.** Sometimes world events result in mankind in general being victimized. World-wide weather patterns creating

drought conditions, and holes in the ozone layer of the earth's atmosphere, affect all of us in one way or another. The spread and threat of incurable killer diseases such as AIDS also affect the earth's population.

### **E. Victim vulnerability**

This dimension contains categories pertaining to characteristics of individuals which make them particularly vulnerable to victimization.

1. Age. Age extremes often render individuals less able to defend themselves. Children are abused and are helpless. The aged are often exploited because they are less able to defend themselves or to stand up for their rights.
2. Sex. For years women have been discriminated against. They are often less physically strong than men, and make easier targets for assault and other types of victimization.
3. Biophysical characteristics (e.g. race, mental retardation and physical illnesses or handicap). People who are at a disadvantage due to physical handicap are often more likely to be taken advantage of or exploited, and therefore are often easier targets for crimes. In addition, certain racial groups often fall prey to discrimination in the work place as well as in the delivery of financial services.
4. Psychological characteristics (e.g. mental disturbance and special mental states). A primary example of such victimization would be the lack of adequate care and treatment for those individuals in state institutions who are not in a financial position to afford quality mental health intervention.
5. Social characteristics (e.g. minority groups and socio-economic status). An example of this type of victimization would be those individuals in minority groups who are unable to acquire the same rights or privileges as others in the community because they are discriminated against in one fashion or another.

The above categories are not mutually exclusive and a variety of combinations is possible. For example, the sexual abuse of a mentally retarded girl who belongs to an underprivileged minority group, constitutes a combination of categories 1, 2, 3 and 5 of this dimension.

### **F. The victim's perception of victimization**

The victim's perception of his or her own victimization is an important aspect of our typology. This dimension contains four categories.

1. Accurate self-perception of victim status. Most victims are aware of the actions committed against them, sense the harm done, and perceive themselves to be victims. While the degree of trauma may range from

little or none to major impact on the individual, most victims recognize that what was done was wrong or harmful, and that they were affected by it in some way.

2. Inaccurate self-perception of victim status. There are occasions when people experience an event or happening and claim victim status even when they have not been victimized. An example would be an individual who knowingly trespasses into a building which is clearly marked *Condemned* and falls through a rotten floor, sustaining injury. In such cases, the victim is, at best, a victim of his own negligent, irresponsible action.
3. Non-perception of victim status. There are a wide variety of instances in which people are truly victimized but do not perceive themselves as victims. In some of these cases, the individual writes off the victimization as a fact of life or simply accepts that this is 'the way things are supposed to be'. An example of such a case would be a country where the law states that it is illegal for anyone over the age of eighteen to engage in sexual activity with anyone, male or female, under the age of eighteen. If a fifteen year old boy develops an attraction to a 22 year old woman and has sex with her, he will probably not view himself as a victim. Since he is consenting, the woman may not view her actions as victimizing him, whatever the law says. In reality this is a case of sexual abuse according to the laws of that country. Another example would be a woman who has her bicycle stolen from her home because she forgot to lock it up. The victim in this case may not claim victim status because she feels it is her fault for forgetting to lock the bicycle, even though leaving a bicycle unlocked is not an invitation for someone else to steal it.
4. Ignorance of the victimization. While these cases may be less common, they do exist. People can be victimized and never be aware of it, or in some cases the victimization may come to their attention at a later point in time. A case in point is property damage which goes unrecognized for a period of time and is brought to the owner's attention through another unrelated individual. Another example is that of a person who engages in a financial transaction such as the purchase of a home and is deliberately not informed that there are major structural problems which are discovered some time after the transaction takes place. Many victims of white-collar criminals fall within this category. One critical question which arises here, for example in connection with medical victimization, is whether or not there is an obligation to inform the patient of the event, and whether such action would be considered ethical if the victim were ignorant of the victimization. Would such information lead to unnecessary trauma if the person were now to be informed; should professionals assist victims in seeing that they have been victimized? These questions are beyond the scope of this paper but merit further inquiry.

## G. Others' perception of victimization

Quinney (1974) emphasizes that 'the victim' is a social construction, a status ascribed to certain individuals who are perceived as such. However, there are occasions when victims' perception of their victimization may differ from that of others. Others' perception of a victimization may reinforce or color the victim's own perception of the event. This dimension contains four categories.

1. Accurate perception of victim status. Here, the victim is unequivocally perceived by others to be a victim; e.g. individuals who lose their home as a result of flooding will be perceived by others as victims of a natural disaster following a storm.
2. Inaccurate perception of victim status. In this case others see an individual as a victim when in fact the person is not a victim. A clear example of this would be an individual who through negligence loses control of his car and runs off the road into a tree, but convinces the police and others that he was run off the road by another reckless driver.
3. Non-perception of victim status. There are occasions when a person is truly victimized but, for various reasons, others do not believe the victimization has occurred. A classic example of this would be a woman who is raped by a man who is a highly respected member of the community.
4. Ignorance of the victimization. These types of victimizations often occur and typically involve threats, blackmail or other forms of duress. One example is a child who is sexually abused by a relative who threatens physical harm if the child should tell anyone about the event. Another example is a man who blackmails a woman into having sex with him by threatening to tell her husband that she has had several extra-marital affairs. The reluctance to report certain types of victimization as well as the prevalence of this phenomenon ('dark figures') is widely discussed in the criminological and victimological literature and is also reflected in the findings of victim surveys (see among others Conklin, 1986; Hagan, 1987; Incidardi, 1984).

## H. Type of victimization

The type of harm or damage is another key component of the victimology field. An event or action must occur in order for an individual to claim victim status. These events or happenings can occur in a variety of ways. While this breakdown is not conclusive, the six sub types/areas account for the more common victimizations which prevail in the world today.

1. Physical harm/damage. Physical harm or damage can occur in a variety

of ways. Natural sources of victimization such as an earthquake can lead to physical injury. Accidents can also result in temporary or permanent physical injury to an individual. A major source of victimization is of course physical violence committed by another.

2. Sexual abuse. Sexual abuse can take place in a variety of ways, such as rape, child sexual abuse, exhibitionism and voyeurism.
3. Economic damage. For many individuals, the impact of victimization is economic in nature; for example someone who loses only cash following a burglary.
4. Psychological damage. One of the most common abuses, especially among children, is psychological abuse. These victims typically hear how worthless they are, how stupid they are and that they will not grow up to amount to anything. Psychological abuse often occurs in marriages where spouse abuse is present as well.
5. Damage to reputation. The intent behind the infliction of such damage could be either accidental or deliberate (slander or libel), but in either case the victim's personal or professional reputation is blemished and the outcome of such victimization can result in interpersonal damage, and in career or professional damage affecting livelihood.
6. Infringement of civil/human rights (e.g. freedom of speech, of religious worship and of physical mobility). A common form of victimization is that which infringes the freedoms of other human beings. This type of victimization is most common in respect to minority groups.

The above categories are not mutually exclusive; quite frequently several types of victimization take place simultaneously. Robbery may involve both physical harm and economic damage, and spousal violence may involve a combination of physical harm, sexual abuse and psychological damage. Thus, in the future specific combinations of types of victimization will have to be developed for specific crimes and/or victimization circumstances.

## **I. Severity of victimization/harm**

This dimension deals with the degree or severity of damage or harm experienced by the victim (cf. [Sellin and Wolfgang, 1964](#); Wolfgang et al., 1985). Six categories are identified.

1. None: no harm noted.
2. Mild: some injury present but usually not requiring intervention on the part of a professional.
3. Moderate: injury present and intervention on the part of a professional is necessary. Evaluation is recommended and desirable. Treatment may often be recommended.
4. Severe: injury present and professional intervention is necessary. Periodic evaluation and long term treatment is also necessary. Prognosis without treatment is poor.

5. Extreme: injury to victim is obvious. Periodic evaluation and long term intensive treatment are necessary. Prognosis even with treatment is guarded.
6. Maximal: victim dies as a result of victimization.

It is obvious that this suggested scaling relates only to physical injury. Similar scalings can be developed regarding other types of victimization. (See for example the classic studies of [Sellin and Wolfgang, 1964](#); and [Wolfgang et al., 1985](#)).

## **J. The victim-offender relationship**

This is one of the most important dimensions, which has been extensively dealt with in the literature (see, for example [Amir, 1971](#); [Curtis, 1974](#); [Hentig, 1974](#); [Hindelang, 1976](#); [Landau, 1974](#); [Landau, Drapkin and Arad, 1974](#); [Lindsey, 1984](#); [Russell, 1982](#); [Wolfgang, 1958](#); [Wolfgang and Singer, 1978](#)). It includes the following six categories.

1. Family: anyone related by blood or marriage to the victim.
2. Acquaintance: individuals who are known to the victim socially.
3. Professional (business, employment, services, etc.): individuals who are known to the victim via business relationships only.
4. Stranger: an individual who is not known by the victim in any of the other three above categories.
5. Impersonal: cases in which victimization is caused by general discriminatory policies of authorities against certain social groups (e.g. women and ethnic minorities).
6. Not applicable: this category covers events which result in a victimization to an individual, but do not directly or primarily involve the deliberate or accidental action of another. Natural events fall into this category.

## **K. The victim's contribution to the event**

There are a variety of victimizations in which the victim(s) contribute(s) to or play(s) a significant role in their occurrence. This dimension is widely discussed in the literature under the heading of victim precipitation (see among others: [Amir, 1971](#); [Clinard and Abbott, 1973](#); [Conklin, 1972](#); [Curtis, 1974](#); [Luckenbill, 1977](#); [Voss and Hepburn, 1968](#); [Weis and Borges, 1973](#); [Wolfgang, 1958](#); [Wolfgang and Singer, 1978](#)). The victim's role or contribution may be hazy in situations where there is a question whether the victim's actions contributed to the victimization. Rape is a good example. If, for example, a woman walks alone through a dark

deserted section of town that is known to be a bad neighborhood, the risk of her being assaulted increases despite her legal right to exercise freedom of movement. Obviously, however, the sole responsibility for most crimes is that of the perpetrator. The victim will often not perceive the event in proper perspective.

If, on the other hand, a hunter with a gun deliberately chooses to cross over a 'no trespassing' sign onto private property and is subsequently shot by the property owner, his role or contribution is much more considerable and more clearly defined. Despite the fact that the property owner may still be in violation of the law for shooting another individual, it is a separate issue from the fact that the victim deliberately trespassed and ignored all warnings.

Given the vast number of possible victimization situations and varying degrees by which victims may contribute to their own victimization, such evaluations need to be made on a case by case basis. For the purposes of a typology, it is suggested that a continuum or scaling of victim responsibility be developed. The following five categories may be useful.

1. None. Nothing that the victim said or did contributed to the victimization. Clear examples of this are victimizations resulting from natural sources and in which case the victim was not aware or had no warning that such an occurrence would take place or that the situation posed a threat or danger. Another example which involves a human perpetrator, but in which the victim did not contribute, would be a woman at home asleep who has good home security but who is raped by a man who forcibly breaks into her home.
2. Minimal. A situation in which the victim's actions play a rather small and insignificant role in the victimization, and in whose absence the victimization would have more than likely occurred anyway. Some accidents would fall into this category, such as car accidents when the fault is that of another driver, or buying new tires for one's car and having a blow-out resulting in a car accident because of a defect in the tire.
3. Moderate. A situation in which the victim's actions contributed to the victimization to the degree that the victimization would probably have been preventable if the victim's actions had been different. An example of this type of situation would be the situation of the rape victim who walks through the bad neighborhood alone. The chances are if she had avoided the area, she would have avoided the rape, although there is no guarantee that she would not be raped walking in a safer neighborhood.
4. High. A situation in which the victim's behavior plays a significant role in the victimization occurring. In these situations it can be determined that had the victim's actions been different, the victimization would clearly have been avoidable. An example would be an individual who is not skilled in self-defense and, as a result of witnessing a street fight and attempting to break it up, is assaulted and injured.

TABLE 1

A Conceptual Framework for Victimology: The Dimensions and their Categories

| Dimensions                                     | 1                                         | 2                                           | 3                                | 4                              | 5                      | 6                         | 7                     | 8                   |
|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|
| A. <i>Source of Victimization</i>              | Individual                                | Group                                       | Community                        | State                          | Corporate              | Technological Environment | Interface Environment | Natural Environment |
| B. <i>Legal Framework</i>                      | Criminal Law                              | Civil Law                                   | Transnational, International Law | No Legal Framework             |                        |                           |                       |                     |
| C. <i>Intentionality of Perpetrator</i>        | Intentional                               | Recklessness                                | Negligence                       | Accident                       | Not Applicable         |                           |                       |                     |
| D. <i>Identification of the Victim</i>         | Individual                                | Social Group                                | Corporate                        | Nation(s)                      | Mankind in General     |                           |                       |                     |
| E. <i>Victim Vulnerability</i>                 | Age                                       | Sex                                         | Biophysical Characteristics      | Psychological Characteristics  | Social Characteristics |                           |                       |                     |
| F. <i>Victim's Perception of Victimization</i> | Accurate self-perception of victim status | Inaccurate self-perception of victim status | Non-perception of victim status  | Ignorance of the victimization |                        |                           |                       |                     |

TABLE 1 (continued)

|                                               |                                      |                                        |                                 |                                |                      |                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------|
| G. <i>Other's Perception of Victimization</i> | Accurate perception of victim status | Inaccurate perception of victim status | Non-perception of victim status | Ignorance of the victimization |                      |                                    |
| H. <i>Type of Victimization</i>               | Physical Harm/Damage                 | Sexual Abuse                           | Economic Damage                 | Psychological Damage           | Damage to Reputation | Infringement of Civil/Human Rights |
| I. <i>Severity of Victimization/Harm</i>      | None                                 | Mild                                   | Moderate                        | Severe                         | Extreme              | Maximal                            |
| J. <i>Victim-Offender Relationship</i>        | Family                               | Acquaintance                           | Professional                    | Stranger                       | Impersonal           | Not Applicable                     |
| K. <i>Victim's Contribution to the Event</i>  | None                                 | Minimal                                | Moderate                        | High                           | Maximal              |                                    |

5. Maximal. A situation in which the victim's actions can be described as the dominant cause in the victimization. The clearest example of this would be suicide. Another example would be the case described earlier in which an individual deliberately chooses to ignore a 'no trespassing' sign and is subsequently injured on private property, or a case in which an individual fails to heed warning signs at a construction site and is injured.

## CONCLUSION

Table 1 presents all eleven dimension of our typology and their respective categories. This table demonstrates in a concise way the multidimensional nature of our proposed conceptual framework, which includes not only the objectively observable characteristics of the event and those involved in it (i.e. dimensions A, D, E, H, I, J, K) but also the subjective definitions and perceptions of the event by the victim and others (dimensions F and G respectively), the perpetrators's mental state (dimension C), as well as the official normative framework within which the event is defined (dimension B).

As stated earlier, this conceptual framework should not be considered to be a final and closed classification system. We have included in it those dimensions considered by us as essential. The very structure of our typology enables us or others to construct a great variety of 'victimization profiles' along the eleven dimensions. Obviously, not all theoretically possible combinations exist in reality, but the typology should be tested by applying it to as great a number of victimization situations as possible. As a result of this process it is quite conceivable that the typology will have to be refined and various changes in its structure will be introduced.

It is clear from our definition of victim and from the content of our dimensions that our conception of victimology goes far beyond the realm of criminal law. However, we are aware of the fact that a great number of victimologists (probably most of them) do confine themselves within the boundaries of criminal law. Our classification could in this respect be of great utility in defining and setting the boundaries of various subdivisions within the large field of victimology. Indeed, the categories within each dimension could be utilized for this purpose. Our proposed approach could also be used as a classification system for the past studies and as a methodological guideline for future studies. For example, an examination of the forty-four propositions constituting Knudsten's (1988b) theory of victimization reveals that the use of our conceptual framework could avoid unnecessary overlapping between some propositions on the one hand, and add some aspects not covered by the theory, on the other. Future research should thus focus on taking this conceptual framework and implementing it in empirical research in order to refine it. Such empirical research is the

only way to validate its usefulness. In cases where it is not completely applicable, new dimensions and categories could be developed or the existing ones reorganized.

## ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The idea to write this paper evolved during the authors' participation in the Fourth International Institute on Victimology, NATO Advanced Research Workshop, which took place in Il Ciocco, Tuscany, Italy, August 1987. The intellectually stimulating atmosphere at that workshop and the initial positive feedback of the participants to our ideas were very encouraging. We would like to express our gratitude to all our colleagues at that workshop. An earlier version of this paper was presented at the 6th International Symposium of Victimology, Jerusalem, Israel, August–September, 1988. The valuable remarks of Menachem Amir and Leslie Sebba are much appreciated.

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